

THE HIDDEN DOUBLE

Although Mizar (ζ) and its neighbor Alcor may appear to be a double star when seen with the naked eye (see main picture), upon further magnification, Mizar (on the left of this image) is revealed to have an even closer companion than Alcor (on the right).

A FAMILIAR SIGHT

The saucepan shape of the Big Dipper's stars is one of the most easily recognized sights in the night sky, but it makes up only part of the whole constellation pattern of Ursa Major.

MYTHS AND STORIES**THE TALE OF THE GREAT BEAR**

The Big Dipper is one of the oldest, most recognized patterns in the sky. In Greek myth, it represents the rump and long tail of the Great Bear. Two characters are identified with it: Callisto, who was one of Zeus's lovers (see p.187); and Adrastea, a nymph who nursed the infant Zeus and was later placed in the sky as the Great Bear.

RECURRING PATTERN

The shape of the Big Dipper can be seen clearly (below, center) on this northern polar chart from Dunhuang, China, dating from around 650 ce.

